

AI in Real Estate

From chatbot to operating layer

A practical guide to playbooks, connected systems, local file work, and recurring routines for teams that want AI to do more than answer questions.

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Skills

The model is not the bottleneck. The operating layer is.

Most teams already have access to capable AI. What they lack is a clear way to connect that intelligence to the process, data, files, and cadence of real work.

01

Playbooks

Package the team's method so the AI follows repeatable steps.

02

Connections

Give the AI controlled access to CRM, property, and market systems.

03

Workspace

Let the AI create and edit approved files where the team works.

04

Routines

Run recurring research, reporting, and follow-up without starting over.

IMPORTANT

This is a practitioner field guide, not survey research. It makes no claims about market-wide adoption rates.

THE OPERATING MODEL

AI creates value when four layers work together.

The names differ by platform. The architecture does not.

4

ROUTINES

When should the work run?

3

WORKSPACE

Where should the output live?

2

CONNECTIONS

What live systems can it reach?

1

PLAYBOOKS

How should the task be done?

THE ALTR POINT OF VIEW

Prompt-only use starts at the top of the conversation and ends when the tab closes. An operating layer preserves the method, reaches the source, produces a usable artifact, and repeats on the right cadence.

Playbooks: make the method reusable

Claude calls them Skills. Other platforms use custom instructions, projects, or purpose-built assistants.

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Skills

A useful playbook packages two things: the context the AI needs and the steps it should follow. That keeps the team's method from disappearing when a conversation ends.

EXAMPLES FROM THE ARTICLE

01

Carry context

Preserve source hierarchy, investment criteria, assumptions, and the delivery format instead of retyping them.

02

Create the Skill

Draft with Claude, write the instructions directly, or upload an existing package, then refine it with the team.

03

Earn trust

Test the playbook against a real deal, inspect the output, and revise the method before expanding its scope.

CHAPTER TAKEAWAY

A playbook is the difference between asking AI to improvise and giving it the method your team already trusts.

Applied: an office-condo underwriting playbook

A repeatable sequence drawn from the Skills article.

THE SCENARIO

The acquisitions team receives an offering memorandum and needs a review-ready ten-year cash-flow model that follows its own criteria and spreadsheet format.

THE WORKFLOW

- 01

Read the OM

Extract property facts, pricing, income, expenses, tenant details, and the assumptions already provided.
- 02

Identify the gaps

List the assumptions the OM does not cover instead of quietly filling them with guesses.
- 03

Confirm assumptions

Resolve missing inputs against the team’s investment criteria and due-diligence checklist.
- 04

Build the cash flow

Create the ten-year projection in the required underwriting sequence.
- 05

Deliver the model

Save the model in the team’s format with assumptions and open questions visible.

USABLE DELIVERABLE

A review-ready underwriting model, an assumptions log, and a short list of unresolved diligence questions.

HUMAN REVIEW

An analyst validates source values, approves assumptions, checks formulas, and decides whether the deal advances.

START HERE Choose one property type and one approved template. Build the first playbook around that narrow lane.

Connections: stop making people carry the data

Connectors give an AI controlled access to the systems and records that hold the current truth.

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Connectors

Copying emails, exporting property reports, and pasting CRM notes makes the team the integration layer. A connector creates a governed route to the source instead.

EXAMPLES FROM THE ARTICLE

01

Connect the CRM

Turn business cards or prospecting notes into structured records, prepare follow-ups, and summarize relationship history.

02

Reach operations

Retrieve rent, leases, billing, work orders, and reporting from Yardi or another property system.

03

Build the missing door

Use a custom connector when a private system, public record, or market source has no packaged integration.

CHAPTER TAKEAWAY

Connect the smallest useful source first, define its authority, and keep sensitive actions behind approval.

Applied: research an 80,000 SF Tampa warehouse

A local-property research workflow adapted from the Connectors article.

THE SCENARIO

A broker or acquisitions lead needs property, ownership, and relationship context before deciding whether an industrial opportunity deserves deeper diligence.

THE WORKFLOW

- 01

Resolve the property

Use the street address or parcel identifier to find the county property record.
- 02

Read public records

Collect appraiser details and relevant deed history from the county sources.
- 03

Match ownership

Trace the ownership entity through Sunbiz and connect related names where the evidence supports it.
- 04

Add relationship context

Check the CRM for prior conversations, referrals, notes, and known contacts.
- 05

Prepare the brief

Organize the facts, sources, open questions, and recommended next actions for review.

USABLE DELIVERABLE

A sourced acquisition brief with property facts, ownership context, known relationships, and diligence gaps.

HUMAN REVIEW

A team member confirms entity matches, validates public-record dates, and decides whether outreach or underwriting begins.

START HERE Begin read-only with one county, one property type, and one defined research brief.

Workspace: make the output usable

The real upgrade is not a better answer. It is a model that can work on the files the team will actually use.

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Cowork

Browser chat creates a loop of upload, prompt, download, open, revise, and upload again. A governed project folder keeps sources, templates, working files, and deliverables together.

EXAMPLES FROM THE ARTICLE

01

Scope the project

Give the AI access to the folder it needs, not the entire computer or every shared drive.

02

Structure the files

Separate source documents, approved templates, working drafts, review copies, and final outputs.

03

Work on the artifact

Read the OM, build the model, save it locally, and continue editing the same approved file.

CHAPTER TAKEAWAY

A useful AI workflow ends in the file or system where the next person can review and act.

Applied: remove the underwriting download loop

A before-and-after workflow drawn from the Cowork article.

THE SCENARIO

The team currently uploads an OM, prompts the model, downloads a spreadsheet, opens Excel, requests revisions, and repeats the handoff.

THE WORKFLOW

- 01 Create the project** Place the OM and approved underwriting template in one deliberately scoped folder.
- 02 Read the source** Extract the relevant facts and record missing assumptions without moving files between tools.
- 03 Build in place** Create the underwriting model directly in the project and preserve the team's structure.
- 04 Review the assumptions** Let the analyst inspect sources, formulas, notes, and unresolved questions.
- 05 Continue the same file** Make approved revisions to the existing model instead of generating another disconnected copy.

USABLE DELIVERABLE

One controlled project containing the source OM, approved template, working model, review notes, and final deliverable.

HUMAN REVIEW

The analyst owns assumptions, formula checks, version approval, and the decision to treat a file as authoritative.

START HERE Choose a single live deal and agree on the folder structure before granting access.

Routines: turn repeated checks into a cadence

Scheduled work keeps a pulse on the market without asking someone to remember the same prompt every week.

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Scheduled Tasks

A routine combines a defined job, approved source access, an output format, and a schedule. It can run on demand or recur daily, weekly, or around a business event.

EXAMPLES FROM THE ARTICLE

01

Define once

Describe the goal, market, lookback window, source data, output format, and limits the task should observe.

02

Deliver the change

Show what happened since the prior run, why it matters, and which items require a decision.

03

Name the reviewer

Assign an owner, escalation path, retention rule, and a response when the routine fails.

CHAPTER TAKEAWAY

If the team checks the same source on the same cadence, it is a candidate for a routine.

Applied: a weekly recent-sales digest

A recurring local-market workflow adapted from the [Scheduled Tasks](#) article.

THE SCENARIO

An acquisitions or brokerage team wants a reliable view of every relevant sale recorded during the previous seven days without restarting the research each week.

THE WORKFLOW

01

Trigger the run

Start weekly on a fixed day, with an on-demand option when an urgent market question appears.

02

Query the sources

Use the approved connector to read county appraiser and deed records for the target market.

03

Apply the filters

Limit results by geography, property type, lookback window, and any known exclusion rules.

04

Build the digest

Organize the properties, transaction details, ownership context, and links to supporting records.

05

Route the review

Notify the market owner and highlight records that need verification or follow-up.

USABLE DELIVERABLE

A concise weekly digest that shows new transactions, supporting sources, and the items worth discussing.

HUMAN REVIEW

A market expert resolves uncertain matches, adds local context, and determines whether research or outreach follows.

START HERE Define the market and review format before scheduling the first recurring run.

An 80,000 SF Tampa industrial brief, end to end

Adapted from the local-property research example in the Connectors article.

01

SOURCE

Bring in the truth

County deeds, appraiser records, Sunbiz ownership records, CRM relationships, and internal deal criteria.

02

PLAYBOOK

Apply the team's method

Match the ownership entities, identify relevant comps, calculate key ratios, and flag missing assumptions.

03

WORKSPACE

Produce the deliverable

Write the brief, update the model, and save a review-ready package.

04

ROUTINE

Keep the market moving

Run weekly, compare against the prior digest, and notify the acquisitions lead.

CHAPTER TAKEAWAY

The value is in the handoffs: source to method, method to artifact, artifact to recurring decision.

WHERE TO START

Pick work that is repeated, reviewable, and close to a decision.

ACQUISITIONS

OM extraction, comp research, assumptions log, underwriting package

SSi

ASSET MANAGEMENT

Variance review, lease abstraction, property update digest, owner reporting

BROKERAGE

CRM follow-up, ownership research, tour notes, proposal preparation

PROPERTY OPERATIONS

Work-order triage, tenant communication drafts, recurring exception reports

DEVELOPMENT

Document control, meeting actions, schedule changes, draw-package checks

CAPITAL MARKETS

Maturity monitoring, lender research, market update summaries, pipeline review

CHAPTER TAKEAWAY

Favor workflows with clear inputs, a visible output, and a human who already knows what good looks like.

CHOOSE THE FIRST WORKFLOW

The best pilot is useful before it is impressive.

Score candidate workflows against three practical signals. A strong first project is repeated, reviewable, and close to a decision.

01

Repeated

The same steps recur often enough that the team already feels the drag.

02

Reviewable

An experienced person can inspect the output and explain what good looks like.

03

Decision-adjacent

The result helps someone act, prioritize, approve, or investigate.

CANDIDATE COMPARISON

WORKFLOW	REPEAT	REVIEW	DECISION
OM extraction and assumptions log	HIGH	HIGH	HIGH
Weekly recent-sales digest	HIGH	HIGH	HIGH
CRM contact entry and follow-up draft	HIGH	HIGH	MED
Lease abstraction and exception list	MED	HIGH	HIGH
Open-ended market strategy	LOW	LOW	HIGH

CHAPTER TAKEAWAY

Start where the team can verify quality quickly. Trust grows from visible, reviewable work.

READINESS SCORECARD

Eight questions before you automate the workflow

- ☐ 01 Can the team describe the task in the same sequence?
- ☐ 02 Are the required sources known and accessible?
- ☐ 03 Is there a clear system of record?
- ☐ 04 Can a human review the output in minutes, not hours?
- ☐ 05 Are sensitive data and permissions understood?
- ☐ 06 Is there a named owner for exceptions and failures?
- ☐ 07 Does the workflow happen often enough to matter?
- ☐ 08 Can success be measured with a before-and-after baseline?

Six or more yes answers: strong pilot candidate. Fewer than six: clarify the process before adding automation.

A 30-day path from idea to trusted workflow

Keep the first deployment narrow enough to learn, but real enough to matter.

WEEK 1

Map

Understand the work

Observe the current process, capture the baseline, identify inputs, decisions, systems, and review points.

WEEK 2

Build

Create the first system

Write the playbook, connect the minimum data, define the workspace, and produce the first real output.

WEEK 3

Run

Learn from real use

Test on live work with human review. Record errors, missing context, and the moments where judgment matters.

WEEK 4

Harden

Make it operable

Set permissions, exception handling, ownership, and measurement. Decide whether to expand, revise, or stop.

CHAPTER TAKEAWAY

A pilot is successful when the team learns what to trust, what to review, and what to build next.

The AI workflow canvas

Use one page to define the work before choosing a model, connector, or automation.

1 / WORKFLOW

What repeated job should the system help complete?

OWNER + CADENCE

Who reviews it, and how often?

2 / INPUTS

Documents, emails, records, notes, or events

3 / SYSTEMS

CRM, property platform, files, public data

4 / CURRENT STEPS

Write the process in the order the team performs it today.

5 / DELIVERABLE

What usable artifact should exist at the end?

6 / HUMAN REVIEW

What must a person verify, approve, or decide?

7 / SUCCESS MEASURE

Time, quality, coverage, response, or risk

8 / FIRST SAFE SCOPE

Smallest live version worth testing

Bring a completed canvas to altr and we can map the operating layer around the work your team already does.

Bring us one workflow your real estate team repeats.

We will map the work, identify the right operating layer, and show your team what a practical AI deployment looks like inside the business you already run.

FREE WORKING SESSION

Map one workflow with us.

altrwork.com/start-a-conversation.html

SOURCE SERIES

Claude in CRE: Skills / Connectors / Cowork / Scheduled Tasks

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Originally published by Jarred Robidoux in the altr'd LinkedIn newsletter. This field guide adapts the series for teams using different AI platforms.

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AI enablement and automation for teams doing real work.